RAMBAM'S INTRODUCTION TO HELEK: OLAM HABA & THE 13 PRINCIPLES

# What Is the Ultimate Reward?

Rambam's Introduction to Helek, Part 1

**Source:** The Rambam's Introduction to Perek Helek (Commentary on the Mishnah, Sanhedrin ch. 10), opening

**Shiur:** Part 1 of the series on the Rambam's Introduction to Perek Helek, given by Dayan Daniel Kada on Zoom, Tuesday 2 September 2025

*These notes are based on the Sofer.ai transcript of the recording.*

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## The Fourth and Final Introduction

| Introduction | Focus | When |
|---|---|---|
| **To Avot** (*Shemonah Perakim*) | A person's **moral and ethical growth**, the soul | Last year |
| **To the Mishnah** | **Legal**: the Oral Torah, its transmission, the Sages' authority, the Mishnah's structure | The past few months |
| **To the Mishneh Torah** | **Legal**: transmission; the authority of the Sanhedrin and the Gemara | Short |
| **To Perek Helek** | **The philosophical and theological underpinnings of the Torah**, and the source of the **13 Principles** | **Now** |

**Perek Helek** is the final or penultimate chapter of Sanhedrin (the penultimate in the Rambam's version), named for its opening: who has a **חלק**, a portion, in the World to Come. Since the Mishnah raises who has and hasn't a portion, the Rambam takes the opening to discuss **what Olam HaBa is**, and the **actions and beliefs** that include or exclude a person, along with **Mashiach, techiyat hametim, Gan Eden and Gehinom**.

### The first Jewish creed

Before the Rambam, Sages told us what Jews believe (**Rav Saadia's *Emunot veDeot***, studied on Monday nights). But **no one formulated a creed**: *these* you must believe to be part of the Jewish people. **The Rambam was the very first**, and "**much has been written**, Torah and academic, on whether it responded to the cultures around him, to Christianity." It "**stuck**":

- **יגדל**, sung on Friday night in many communities, condenses the 13 Principles.
- **אני מאמין באמונה שלמה**, said after Shacharit (Ashkenazi siddurim and some Sephardi).
- Today, denying one makes you "a *kofer*."

### The halachic stakes

The Rambam writes (we'll see it inside): **one who rejects any of the 13 is not part of Israel.**

- **Shechitah:** kosher shechitah must be done by a **Yisrael**. One who rejects the 13 "**isn't a Yisrael**", so his meat isn't kosher. "**Unbelievable.**"

- **Minyan:** seemingly he can't count either. "We don't interrogate people. But if someone **publicly** renounced a principle, it's a real halachic issue."

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## The Mishnah

**כל ישראל יש להם חלק לעולם הבא, שנאמר: ועמך כלם צדיקים, לעולם יירשו ארץ, נצר מטעי, מעשה ידי להתפאר.**

**ירשו ארץ** = **ארץ החיים**, the metaphorical land above (**לולא האמנתי לראות בטוב ה׳ בארץ חיים**).

**נצר מטעי**: the planting of **Gan Eden**: **ויטע ה׳ אלהים גן בעדן**.

- **The default: every Jew has a portion**, commensurate with his deeds, **even one executed** for Shabbat-breaking, adultery or murder. (Today, with no executions, an unrepented capital sin is "a different question.")

### The exceptions

| | |
|---|---|
| **האומר אין תחיית המתים** | Some texts add **מן התורה** (denying it's hinted in the Torah). **The Rambam's text lacks it**: you must believe in resurrection, not necessarily that it's in the Torah |
| **אין תורה מן השמים** | What *that* means is itself huge. "Those who know British Jewish history will know the **greatest rabbinic scandal** of the century: **the Louis Jacobs affair** in the '50s and '60s, over exactly this" |
| **אפיקורוס** | Two explanations: a follower of **Epicurus**'s heretical philosophy; or from **הפקר**, treating the Torah and its Sages as **ownerless**, free to denigrate |
| **Rabbi Akiva: הקורא בספרים החיצונים** | Reading forbidden books |
| **הלוחש על המכה: כל המחלה אשר שמתי במצרים** | **Using verses as medicine**: "the Rambam was **very sharp** on this" |
| **Abba Shaul: ההוגה את השם באותיותיו** | **Pronouncing the Divine Name as written**, the four letters, instead of *Ad-nai* |

Here is the right place to discuss many" **ראיתי לדבר כאן עיקרים רבים באמונה, גדולים ונכבדים עד מאד.** ".great principles of faith

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## Five Mistaken Views of Reward

He **begins with the wrong answers**. Even **people of Torah** disagree widely on **the good that comes from keeping the mitzvot** and **the harm from transgressing**:

**...ונשתבשו בה הסברות שבוש גדול, עד שכמעט לא תמצא בשום פנים אדם שנתבאר לו הדבר הזה.**

There's such confusion that **you'll hardly find anyone clear on it.**

"I think not much has changed. Ask the average Jew on the street: you'll get all kinds of answers, but rarely a clear one. There are so many statements (in the Torah, the Sages, different shiurim) that seem to contradict, and **no one puts it all together.**"

| | Ultimate reward | Ultimate punishment | Support claimed |
|---|---|---|---|
| **1. Gan Eden** | **A place where you eat and drink without toil**: houses of precious stones, beds spread with silk, **rivers of wine and perfumed oils** | **Gehinom**: a place **burning with fire** where bodies are burnt, with all kinds of suffering | **"Most" rabbinic statements and verses**, read plainly |
| **2. The days of Mashiach** | Everyone **like angels**, living **forever**, **growing in stature**; Mashiach himself lives forever; the earth yields **woven garments and baked bread** | **Not being there** | Some statements |
| **3. Techiyat hametim** | Living again after death, **back with your family**: eating, drinking, never dying | **Not rising** with them | Statements and verses |
| **4. This world** | **Rest and worldly pleasure**: fertile land, wealth, many children, health, **peace and security**, **a Jewish king** over our enemies | The opposite: "**as we are today, in exile**" | **The Torah's own blessings and curses**: "you don't need to look further than **Ki Tavo**" |
| **5. All of the above** (most people) | Mashiach comes, the dead rise, they enter Gan Eden, eat, drink and are healthy forever | Missing it all | |

**On Gehinom:** "You've heard the stories. Read **Rav Chaim Vital**'s *Sefer HaChezyonot*, his diary of life with **the Arizal**: **very graphic** descriptions."

## "Gan" and "Eden" are two places

The Rambam (in **Rav Shilat's and Rav Kafih's** text) writes **גן ועדן**, which the printed abbreviation hides. Many Gemaras treat them as **two**:

- **Berachot: עין לא ראתה אלהים זולתך**: Rabbi Levi: **wine preserved in its grapes since the six days of creation**; Rabbi Shmuel bar Nachmani: **that's Eden, which no eye has seen**. *But Adam was there?* **He was in the *Gan*. ונהר יצא מעדן להשקות את הגן**: **Gan is one thing, Eden another.** Eden is reserved for the righteous.

- Another Gemara: **Egypt is 1/60 of Kush, the world 1/60 of the Garden, the Garden 1/60 of Eden, Eden 1/60 of Gehinom.** "What that means, I can't tell you. But they're **two places**."

## The common denominator

**Class answer:** *they're all physical.* "**Excellent.**" Wine, a long-lived king, family, bread on trees: **all physical**.

## What People Should Ask, and What They Do Ask

**אבל זה הענין הנפלא ורעיון העולם הבא, מעט תמצא בשום פנים שיעלה על לבו.**

Hardly anyone even **asks where Olam HaBa fits**: is it the goal, or one of the five? Which is the goal, and which **the means** to it?

**What everyone asks instead:**

**Will the dead rise naked or clothed?** In the **shrouds** they were buried in, or in their fine clothes (*"so I can still show off my Prada shoes"*)? When Mashiach comes, will there be **rich and poor**, strong and weak?

**A dig at Rav Saadia** (unnamed): his essay on resurrection asks exactly these, ten questions (*what clothes? will I recognise my loved ones?*). The Rambam: you can discuss them, **but that's not the essence.**

In fairness, the **Gemara (Sanhedrin 90b)** records **Queen Cleopatra** asking **Rabbi Meir** whether the dead rise clothed. He said **clothed**. The Rambam would say he **answered because she asked**.

*"And what age will we be resurrected at? If it's one, the clothes won't fit!"* "**I'll worry about it when it happens.** The Rambam writes elsewhere that **no one knows** these answers, about Mashiach or resurrection. **When it comes, you'll see.**"

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## The Parable of the Child

He knows he's going against the masses, so first, an analogy.

**A young child is brought to a teacher to learn Torah.** It's the greatest good for him, but being young and immature, **he doesn't see its value.** So the teacher, more mature, must **motivate him with things he loves**.

| Age | Incentive | "To him, the goal is..." |
|---|---|---|
| **Young child** | **Nuts, figs, honey**: "today, **sweets**" | The sweet. Learning is toil endured for it |
| **Older** (8 or 9) | **Nice shoes, fine clothes** | The clothes |
| **Teenager** | **A dinar or two**: "**£10** for this chapter" | The money |
| **Young adult** | **"Learn so you'll be a leader, a dayan, and people will honour you and stand for you"** | **Honour**, praise, admiration |

"*Look at that gadol, how people honour him; learn properly and you'll be like him.* We hear this all the time. The Rambam says 'unfortunately'; **I'm not sure it's unfortunate. At that age, it's probably what you need to tell yeshivah students.**"

> **All of this is unworthy**, but **necessary**, because people take time to mature. The **וכל זה מגונה.** Sages call it **שלא לשמה**, not for its own sake, and warned: **אל תעשם עטרה להתגדל בהם ולא קרדום לחפור בהם.**

**The true goal:**

**אין תכלית לימוד החכמה אלא לדעת אותה, ואין תכלית האמת אלא שתדע שהוא אמת. והתורה אמת, ותכלית ידיעתה לעשותה.**

**The purpose of wisdom is to know it; the purpose of truth is to know that it's true. The Torah is truth, and the purpose of knowing it is to do it.**

## "What do I get?"

**A mature person mustn't ask *what reward will I get for these mitzvot?*** That's the child asking *what will you give me if I read?* **The question itself shows immaturity**, so we answer him **according to his level**: **ענה כסיל כאולתו**.

**The implication, though he doesn't say it outright: all those Rabbinic statements about wine, bread on trees, family reunions and fire** are the **sweets, clothes, money and honour**. Tell people *there's no reward, just learn*, and **they'll reject the Torah**.

## Antigonos

**אל תהיו כעבדים המשמשין את הרב על מנת לקבל פרס, אלא... שלא על מנת לקבל פרס.**

He meant: **believe the truth because it's the truth. That's serving from love.**

Rabbi Elazar: **במצותיו חפץ מאד**: **in His commandments, not in their reward.**

- **The Sifrei:** *I'll learn to be rich, to be called Rabbi, to earn Olam HaBa.* **לאהבה את ה'**: **do everything only from love**, **not even for Olam HaBa**.

**The four species.** (Told of the Ba'al Shem Tov, or the Vilna Gaon.) Before Sukkot no *arba minim* could be found; one man in a nearby town had a set. "In Poland you import them; Sephardim, among the date palms, didn't have this problem." The rabbi sent a messenger to pay any sum. The man replied: *not for money, only for the reward of the mitzvah.* **The messenger returned crestfallen. The rabbi was** thrilled**:** *Run back! Finally I can test myself, doing a mitzvah for nothing at all.* **"You can always psychoanalyse the subconscious. But** that's the ideal.**"

## Why the Sages allowed the incentives

**That's the level of Avraham Avinu, who served from love.** But the Sages knew **it's very hard**; few reach it, and slowly. **A person does nothing except for a benefit, or to avoid a loss.** "**We're not naturally altruistic.** We can be, with training." *Imagine telling your children, your congregation: do mitzvot for nothing.***

So **the masses were permitted** to keep mitzvot **hoping for reward** and avoid sin **fearing punishment**, to strengthen them **until they reach completeness**, as with the child.

**Antigonos was criticised**: not for the idea, but for **preaching it constantly**. His students **Tzadok and Baitos** concluded **there's no reward at all**, and broke away.

**And the masses lose nothing** by serving from fear and hope: it builds **strength and habit**, from which **knowledge of the truth** grows, and **they come to serve from love**. **לעולם יעסוק אדם בתורה ובמצות אף שלא לשמן, שמתוך שלא לשמן בא לשמן.**

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## Summary

1. **Perek Helek** is the Rambam's **philosophical** introduction, and the birth of **the first Jewish creed**, with halachic teeth (**shechitah, minyan**).
2. **The Mishnah:** every Jew has a portion, even the executed, **except** those who deny resurrection or Torah from heaven, the *apikoros*, readers of forbidden books, verse-healers, and pronouncers of the Name.
3. **Five mistaken views** of the ultimate reward: **Gan Eden** (wine; Gehinom's fire), **Mashiach's days** (bread on trees), **resurrection** (family), **this world** (Ki Tavo), **all combined**. Their common thread: **they're all physical.** People ask about **shrouds vs Prada shoes**, not **where Olam HaBa fits**.
4. **Gan and Eden are two places.**
5. **The parable of the child: sweets → clothes → money → honour**, all *she-lo lishmah*, **necessary but not the goal**. **Truth is learned because it's true.** Those physical descriptions are **answers to the immature, at their level**.
6. **Serve from love** (Antigonos, Avraham), but **don't preach it to all**; *mitoch she-lo lishmah ba lishmah*.

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## Coming Up

One more introduction: the misconception that **every Rabbinic statement must be taken literally**. Then **what Olam HaBa really is**, and how Mashiach, resurrection and Gan Eden fit around it.

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